

BENEATH THE MAGNOLIA TREE

Genre: Suspense / Family Drama

Setting: Atlanta – Historic West End and surrounding neighborhoods

Treatment:

Dr. Maya Collins is a high-profile trauma therapist with a carefully managed life in Buckhead: pristine condo, curated wardrobe, and a tightly locked emotional vault. But when her estranged mother, Ruthie Mae, dies unexpectedly, Maya is summoned back to the decaying West End bungalow she hasn't visited in over two decades.

Maya's plan is simple—sign the papers, sell the house, and return to her life. But her plans are quickly complicated by the presence of Simone, a guarded 17-year-old claiming to have been Ruthie Mae's live-in caretaker. The catch? Simone insists she's Maya's sister.

As Maya confronts her childhood demons—an abusive father, a mother who turned a blind eye, and a community that once protected her—strange occurrences around the house begin to unnerve her. Forgotten photographs. Whispers in the walls. And Simone, who knows far more about Maya's past than she should.

Through a series of emotional and chilling discoveries, Maya unearths journals, letters, and recordings that reveal a past soaked in family secrets: Ruthie Mae once took in troubled young girls in secret to protect them from abuse, including Simone's mother. Maya begins to understand that her mother's silence wasn't neglect—it was survival.

But someone else knows the truth too. And they want it buried. As threats escalate, Maya must confront not only the dangers surrounding the house but the emotional walls she built inside herself. Ultimately, Maya must decide: will she walk away again—or finally plant roots, heal, and protect the sister she never knew she needed?

Themes:

Family secrets, generational trauma, redemption, Black womanhood, forgiveness, and the idea that sometimes the truth can be both painful and freeing.